

Policy Paper

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Funding for education in crises: Data in distress

Donors fund education in emergencies and protracted crises through both development and humanitarian channels. However, each of the three main mechanisms for reporting financing data offers only a partial view. The lack of alignment between them translates to a lack of a comprehensive picture of the available resources in these contexts. This weakness undermines response efforts, efficient planning and effective advocacy. This paper combines data from the three main reporting mechanisms to provide a global perspective and in-depth national perspective for six countries. It argues that the complementary use of these sources can offer a clearer picture of trends on funding education in crisis-affected contexts.

Key messages

- **Education financing in crisis contexts is often exclusively associated with humanitarian aid.** Looking at humanitarian aid alone, education has consistently been one of the most underfunded sectors. Only 29% of the funding requested for education in emergencies was met in 2024, according to the FTS database.
- **In fact, education financing in crisis contexts has both humanitarian and development objectives.** Yet reporting systems continue to categorize interventions as either humanitarian or development in somewhat arbitrary ways, limiting the ability to monitor education financing in crisis contexts consistently.
- **Seen in this way, development aid accounts for an increasing share of funding for education in crises.** Between 2017 and 2023, the share rose from 70% to 92% although the exact share may be overestimated due to the narrow definition of humanitarian aid according to the CRS database.
- **Reflecting the increase and length of crises, funding for education in crisis accounts for an increasing share of total aid to education.** The share of education in emergencies and protracted crises has increased from 9% in 2016 to 12% in 2023; in countries with humanitarian response plans in place for more than three years, the share rose from 21% to 24% in this period.

Recommendations

A coordinated approach is needed to improve reporting on funding education in emergencies and protracted crises.

- **Align the three main reporting systems – the CRS, FTS and IATI – to reflect the full scope of funding education in crises** and support more accurate tracking with common codes and markers.
- **Improve reporting standards and classification processes in the three databases** to improve the quality and comparability of data between them.
- **Enhance collaboration among the three databases and reporting agencies** to harmonize taxonomies, develop cross-referencing mechanisms and reduce duplication.
- **Make comparable education funding data accessible and actionable** to build a shared, transparent and timely evidence basis and inform decisions across the humanitarian–development continuum.

Armed conflict, climate shocks and forced displacement have become persistent features of global crises. As of mid-2024, there were 122.6 million forcibly displaced people worldwide, among them 43.7 million refugees and 72.1 million internally displaced people (UNHCR, 2024). The average length of a humanitarian appeal stood at 10 years (OCHA, 2024a) and protracted crises characterize 91% of these appeals (Development Initiatives, 2024).

Education in emergencies and protracted crises (EiEPC) is recognized as a vehicle for people to access nutrition, protection, physical health, mental health and other life-saving services in humanitarian responses and as a critical long-term investment for resilience and recovery. Yet, despite widespread recognition of its importance, education remains one of the most neglected sectors in emergency contexts: only 29% of education funding requests in humanitarian appeals were met in 2024 (OCHA, 2025a).

Humanitarian actors are by no means the only ones supporting EiEPC. Development actors are also active in countries affected by emergencies and protracted crises. For example, investments in situations of fragility, conflict and violence account for more than 25% of the World Bank's education portfolio (World Bank, 2022).

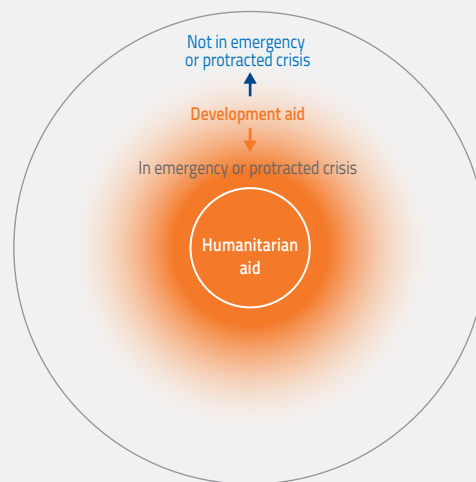
However, while education interventions increasingly span humanitarian and development programming, the mechanisms for financing and tracking humanitarian and development funding for education remain largely separate, monitored through distinct systems with different standards. As a comprehensive overview of resources remains elusive, this fragmentation limits opportunities for strategic planning, funding alignment and effective advocacy.

Three global databases provide information on aid to education: the Organisation for Economic Co-operation and Development (OECD) Creditor Reporting System (CRS), which captures development assistance; the UN Office for the Coordination of Humanitarian Affairs (OCHA) Financial Tracking Service (FTS), which tracks humanitarian assistance within and outside UN-coordinated appeals; and the International Aid Transparency Initiative (IATI) database, to which a wide range of actors report transaction-level data on humanitarian and development aid. But each system offers only a partial view and no single source provides a comprehensive picture of how education is financed in emergencies and protracted crises. This lack of alignment between them undermines efforts to respond to urgent needs, plan effectively and advocate for underfunded priorities.

This paper, developed by Education Cannot Wait (ECW) and the Global Education Monitoring (GEM) Report, consolidates financing data from the three databases to improve understanding of the EiEPC funding landscape, bridging the traditional divide between humanitarian and development financing (Box 1). Depending on the lens applied – coordinated appeals, crisis contexts, intervention types or target populations – the same education activity may or may not be classified as 'humanitarian'. These inconsistencies shape how aid is reported, which funding gaps are visible, and how donor commitments are to be interpreted. As some donors now pledge to safeguard humanitarian education funding in the face of broader cuts, greater clarity is needed to determine what is being protected and which areas may still be at risk of underfunding (Figure 1).

FIGURE 1.

It is difficult to clearly define education financing in emergencies and protracted crises



This paper consists of four sections. First, an introductory section sets out the main issues from a practical perspective: through a description of how the three main databases (CRS, FTS and IATI) can jointly contribute towards an understanding of education funding in emergency and protracted crisis settings and through a country case study that shows the challenges of definition and how they can shape reporting, coordination and planning. Second, the global evidence on financing EiEPC is reviewed, with a particular emphasis on IATI data, which are being analysed for the first time in this paper. Third, the same evidence is reviewed from the perspective of six countries to highlight the opportunities and challenges in defining financing for EiEPC. Finally, recommendations are made to promote more coordinated and effective tracking of aid flows and to support decision making at all levels.



BOX 1.**Humanitarian, emergency, and emergency and protracted crisis contexts overlap but are not the same**

Some terms that describe the financing education of populations whose lives are disrupted or at risk are used interchangeably despite subtle, but substantive, differences between them.

Humanitarian education funding relates to responses under humanitarian plans. These prioritize protection, life-saving assistance and access to temporary learning opportunities; address immediate needs; and are limited in time. However, there is no universally agreed definition of what counts as ‘humanitarian’. In practice, classification may depend on the lens applied, which sometimes differs by practitioners and donors. These lenses include: (i) an institutional lens, by which funding is considered humanitarian if it is part of a coordinated appeal (e.g. a Humanitarian Response Plan (HRP), a Regional Response Plan (RRP)); (ii) a phenomenon lens, by which classification is determined by the nature of the crisis (e.g. conflict, displacement, disaster); (iii) an intervention lens, by which funding is considered humanitarian according to the type of activity (e.g. protective, urgent or time-critical education support); and (iv) a beneficiary lens, by which the target group determines whether funding is humanitarian (e.g. displaced, refugees or crisis-affected learners) (OCHA, 2024b). These lenses may overlap.

Funding under **education in emergencies** (EiE) covers the provision of safe, inclusive and quality learning opportunities in the immediate aftermath of a crisis, with the aim to restore access to education, protect learners and support psychosocial well-being. Typically, these are short-term, time-sensitive interventions delivered during acute emergencies, such as conflict, displacement or natural disasters. Common modalities include temporary learning spaces, emergency school kits, accelerated learning, and psychosocial support for displaced or crisis-affected populations. Because of its focus on immediate responses, EiE is often associated with humanitarian interventions. However, its use in reporting is broader. Some donors report funding under the EiE sector even when it is not formally classified as humanitarian. For the purpose of this paper, EiE refers to education funding reported under the dedicated CRS ‘Education in emergencies’ sector code (OECD, 2017).

In this paper, an **emergencies and protracted crises** (EiEPC) context describes a country or part of a country where education services are significantly disrupted due to armed conflict, forced displacement, natural disasters or other crises, often over extended periods. An active education-related humanitarian appeal (e.g. an HRP or RRP) needs to be in place. Funding for EiEPC can be humanitarian, development or multisector investments that serve crisis-affected learners or strengthen system resilience. They span immediate and longer-term interventions. The focus on emergency and protracted crisis contexts has gained in prominence since the 2016 World Humanitarian Summit, which proposed a ‘new way of working’ to improve coherence in programming between humanitarian and development actors. For example, a successful approach could integrate systemic aspects and disaster risk reduction in humanitarian programme delivery and/or development programming, even if the actors and implementation modalities are different. Much EiEPC-aligned funding is embedded in broader development budgets and is not recognized in humanitarian tracking systems, highlighting the need for more integrated approaches.

DEFINING THE CHALLENGE

Two building blocks are necessary to introduce an analysis of financing for education in humanitarian settings, emergencies and protracted crises. First, it is important to be familiar with the characteristics, relative strengths and weaknesses of the three main information sources on financing education in these contexts in order to assess whether aid can be meaningfully tracked across each one of them. This analysis explores the degree to which these data sets offer comparable or complementary information, identifies overlaps and inconsistencies in donor reporting, and considers whether a combined approach could enhance transparency. It also assesses the potential of IATI to improve monitoring development and humanitarian aid in education. Second, a country example puts the scope of the proposed analysis into perspective.

UNDERSTANDING THE GLOBAL DATA: CRS, FTS AND IATI

The OECD **CRS** is the longest-standing and most comprehensive global database for tracking official development assistance (ODA). It was established in the early 1960s by the OECD Development Assistance Committee (DAC) to standardize reporting and improve transparency in development finance. It provides activity-level data disaggregated by donor, recipient, sector and modality, based on mandatory annual reporting by the 33 DAC member states and voluntary reporting by more than 20 non-DAC members. In development ODA, education is one of the sectors to which aid is allocated, whereas humanitarian ODA is not allocated between sectors, although a code on education in emergencies (72012) was created in 2017.

However, the CRS has limitations. Data are published with a two-year delay and shaped primarily by development-focused reporting standards. Some of this support may reach countries facing protracted crises, but the system does not explicitly identify education aid linked to emergencies. It records some humanitarian aid, including activities with education components such as child protection or multisector responses. However, these are typically not tagged with education sector codes. As a result, part of the support to crisis-affected populations may not be reflected in education ODA statistics.

The **FTS** is a centralized platform managed by OCHA for tracking international humanitarian financing. It was established in 1992 to improve transparency and coordination of funding for UN-led humanitarian appeals (OCHA, 2022). It compiles data voluntarily reported by donors, UN agencies, NGOs and other humanitarian actors in relation to – but not limited to – UN-coordinated response plans, including sector-specific appeals, such as those for education (OCHA, 2025b). The data refer to pledges, commitments and contributions, and indicate whether funding has been provided ('funded') or is pending. It is updated regularly and offers a curated structure for tracking contributions to country, regional and global humanitarian appeals, including refugee response plans coordinated by UNHCR.

The FTS also has limitations. It does not capture disbursements but only the initial flow of funds from donors to agencies. While it provides a timely view of commitments and paid contributions, it does not confirm how these funds are subsequently allocated or whether they ultimately support education activities on the ground. It is primarily designed to monitor short-term humanitarian response funding rather than long-term funding or development assistance. As such, it may not fully reflect funding from donors whose contributions fall outside the scope of coordinated appeals or who do not consistently report through the system.

IATI is an open-data standard and reporting platform, which was launched in 2008 to improve the transparency, coordination and effectiveness of development cooperation. It was established following the Accra Agenda for Action, in response to growing international calls for more accessible and comparable aid data. IATI enables a wide range of development and humanitarian actors (including bilateral donors, multilateral agencies, non-governmental organizations and private sector entities) to publish structured information on their activities. It records data on budgets, commitments and disbursements, along with information on sectors, locations, implementing agencies and activity status. It is hosted by the United Nations Development Programme

(UNDP) in partnership with the UN Office for Project Services (UNOPS). Participation in IATI is voluntary and reporting practices vary across organizations in terms of frequency, level of detail and data completeness. It was designed to complement and expand upon existing reporting systems, particularly in terms of openness, flexibility and broader participation beyond traditional donors.

However, analysing IATI data is not straightforward. To start with, reporting is done at the entity level. Many of the 1,845 entities that have reported education-related activities through IATI are public agencies, foundations and private sector actors that have received rather than offered funding. Without further analysis, the roles of different actors can therefore easily be misinterpreted. Further, the IATI database distinguishes between publishers who upload data, reporters who are named in activity records, and providers who fund activities regardless of whether they report directly. These categories can overlap and do not directly correspond to the definition of a donor used in CRS reporting. Some organizations appear as both funders and recipients, depending on the project. Interpreting data accurately may require cross-referencing (e.g. with the CRS) to avoid duplication or misclassification.

In 2016, IATI introduced a humanitarian marker to support transparency commitments under the Grand Bargain, an agenda for humanitarian aid reform agreed at the 2016 World Humanitarian Summit, and to improve alignment with the FTS. The platform allows education-related activities in crisis contexts to be tagged, although the extent to which these fields are used consistently differs among reporting entities.

UNDERSTANDING COUNTRY REALITIES: A CASE STUDY OF CHAD

To explain the impact of diverse settings and data sources on understanding financing flows to EiEPC, it is necessary to use a practical example of a country grappling with conflict, displacement and fragility. Chad faces one of the world's most complex and protracted crises. It scores 8 out of 10 according to the INFORM Risk Index, a global, open-source risk assessment for humanitarian crises and disasters supported by the European Commission (INFORM, 2025).

Chad hosts over one million forcibly displaced people and faces the impacts of internal instability, cyclical drought, food insecurity, climate shocks and the spillover of regional conflicts (OCHA, 2024c). But these pressures also deepen the long-standing vulnerability of the country's education system. In 2023, the out-of-school rate was 27% among children of primary school age, 58% among adolescents



of lower secondary school age, and 72% among youth of upper secondary school age. Just 34% of children completed primary school within three to five years of their official graduation age and only 50% eventually completed primary school with several more years of delay (UNESCO, 2025a). Of those, only 8% achieved minimum proficiency in reading and just 2% in mathematics in 2019.

These statistics show how difficult it is to distinguish humanitarian from development priorities. Education financing needs to meet urgent needs while building long-term resilience. Yet aid flows are fragmented, coordination structures run in parallel, and there is a lack of clarity over who funds what, where and for whom.

In the five years between 2019 and 2023, the government allocated on average 14.9% of its budget to education, which corresponds to 2.8% of Chad's gross domestic product (UNESCO, 2025b). As domestic resources cover only about 25% of the estimated investment needs of the sector, Chad relies heavily on external aid. According to a 2023 independent evaluation on enabling factors for system transformation commissioned by the Global Partnership for Education (GPE), while 13 development and humanitarian partners contributed to the 2018–2020 Education Sector Plan, all funding was off-budget, disbursed bilaterally through stand-alone systems (GPE, 2023).

There is a mix of humanitarian and development programmes in Chad, coordinated through three platforms: the Local Education Group, the Education Cluster and the Refugee Education Working Group (Dewulf, et al., 2020). Recent short-term programmes include ECW's First Emergency Response window (to address the consequences of the crisis in neighbouring Sudan) and GPE's Accelerated Funding facility (responding to urgent humanitarian needs). These operate alongside longer-term initiatives like ECW's Multi-Year Resilience Programme, GPE's System Transformation and Girls' Education Accelerator grants (as part of the Programme de Refondation de l'École Tchadienne, PRET), and the World Bank's Sahel Regional Engagement for Learning and Collaboration in Education (**Table 1**).

While these initiatives pursue shared goals to increase education access and improve learning outcomes in a context affected by protracted crisis and fragility, limited information sharing between reporting systems, coordination platforms, and national and local levels mean that the government and its development partners miss opportunities to achieve synergies and avoid overlaps (Robiati, 2021). This contributes to duplication, funding gaps and weak alignment with both humanitarian needs and long-term development priorities (GPE, 2023).

Key informant interviews have shed light on the problems with reporting EiEPC financing. The 2024 planning process for the second phase of the Multi-Year Resilience Programme suffered from a lack of a centralized and interoperable reporting system. Efforts to develop an overview of existing and planned education investments relied on personal contacts and ad hoc data collection. This approach proved resource intensive and led to incomplete reporting. It is very difficult to have a full view of EiEPC financing when coordination platforms struggle in their role and data sharing is inconsistent.

In 2024, the Ministry of National Education and Civic Promotion launched an initiative to map finance flows with the Local Education Group, the Education Cluster and the Refugee Education Working Group to improve transparency. While relevant data on past disbursements should be available in the three global platforms, the limitations of the CRS, FTS and IATI – voluntary reporting, uneven awareness levels and inconsistent data standards – limit their usability at the country level.

The example of Chad highlights the need for a more integrated approach to track aid to help decision makers align investments, monitor gaps and respond to needs in real time. The remainder of this paper examines how the CRS, FTS and IATI could be leveraged to generate a more coherent picture of EiEPC financing and how financing data should be reported.

TABLE 1.**Major recent and current humanitarian and development donor programmes in Chad**

Donor	Programme	Duration Budget (USD)	Thematic focus	Geographic focus
Global Partnership for Education	PREAT Projet de renforcement de l'éducation et de l'alphabétisation au Tchad	2018–2024 50 million	Access to primary and non-formal education, teaching quality, institutional capacity	10 priority provinces affected by displacement and food insecurity
	Accelerated Funding (UNESCO)	2021–2024 10 million	Inclusive education in emergencies, community teacher training, data systems	Focus on crisis-affected zones, flexible based on evolving emergencies
	Accelerated Funding (UNICEF)	2023–2025 10 million	School water, sanitation and hygiene (WASH), infrastructure resilience, learning materials	5 provinces (Lac, Logone Oriental, Mayo-Kebbi Est, N'Djamena and Tandjilé)
	PRET Programme de Refondation de l'École Tchadienne (UNICEF and UNESCO)	2025–2028 105.5 million	Teacher training and management, girls' education, improved teaching delivery	Nationwide with 16 priority provinces, refugee dimension not explicitly integrated but adaptable
World Bank	PARCA Support to Refugees and Host Communities	2019–2025 60 million	School construction, community teacher training, decentralized administrative support	3 main refugee-hosting provinces (Lac, Logone Oriental and Ouaddaï)
	Chad Improving Learning Outcomes Project	2022–2027 150 million	Quality teaching, equitable access, fee reduction, disability and refugee inclusion	Nationwide, targeting 2.8 million students in public and community schools
	RELANCE Sahel Regional Engagement for Learning and Collaboration in Education	2025–2030 23 million	Regional policy coordination, open school for nomadic and refugee youth, hybrid learning	Nationwide, regional with Chad and Mauritania, targets 850,000 out-of-school youth
Education Cannot Wait	MYRP Multi-Year Resilience Program (UNICEF)	2024–2027 20 million	Inclusive access, safe/resilient learning environments, climate-adaptive schools	Logone Oriental and Ouaddaï
	FER First Emergency Response – Sudan Crisis (UNHCR)	2024 5 million	Access to inclusive education, quality learning, mental health and psychosocial support (MHPSS), community engagement	Eastern Chad: Ouaddaï, Sila, Wadi-Fira and Ennedi Est

INSIGHTS FROM A GLOBAL ANALYSIS OF EIEPC FINANCING DATA SOURCES

To carry out a globally comparable analysis of EiEPC financing, a common set of filters was applied to the CRS and IATI databases. Records were included if they contained a CRS-equivalent sector code and were tagged under education (430), development food assistance (520), emergency education (72012), or relief coordination and support services (72050). Entries tagged as emergency food assistance (72040) and material relief assistance and services (72010) were excluded, as records under these codes had no clear attribution to education.

As neither the CRS nor IATI include a dedicated marker for education in emergencies (except for 72012), the analysis relied on keyword searches. First, records under education

sector codes were screened for references to crisis-related activities to capture support that may not be explicitly labelled as EiEPC. Second, records under humanitarian and food assistance sector codes were screened to identify transactions where education was a component, even if the primary sector code did not reflect it. The list of keywords is available in an online annex.

As noted above, the CRS has two disadvantages for this analysis. First, it has a two-year time lag, while both the FTS and IATI provide more recent data. Second, although a marker for education in emergencies exists, it has not yet been introduced systematically, which makes it harder to identify relevant activities and may therefore result in underestimating education in humanitarian aid, for example when compared to data from the FTS.



The FTS does not require the same filtering because it identifies education based on humanitarian funding aligned with UN appeals. While it offers a timely view of commitments and paid contributions, it does not track how these funds are subsequently allocated or spent by agencies (High-Level Panel on Humanitarian Financing, 2016; OCHA, 2025c; OCHA, 2025d) and therefore whether they ultimately support education.

The IATI database provides detailed transaction-level data, but its structure creates challenges, as many IATI-reporting entities are intermediaries or implementers, not donors. This requires extra filtering and cross-checking with CRS and institution-level data. The analysis was limited to entities identified as donors in the OECD CRS or as UN agencies.

The quality of reporting in IATI also varies, especially for fields such as provider names or transaction types.

Among 27 bilateral and 35 multilateral donors identified in the data set, only a few donors report disbursement data regularly over multiple years. In total, 17 donors were found to report consistently and with enough detail to track disbursements on education in emergencies: the African Development Bank, Asian Development Bank, Belgium, Canada, Denmark, the European Union, Finland, France, Germany, Italy, the Netherlands, Norway, the Republic of Korea, Saudi Arabia, the United Kingdom, the United States and the World Bank (International Development Association). By contrast, GPE and ECW data are not included (**Box 2**).

BOX 2.

Tracking GPE and ECW disbursements on EiEPC is not straightforward

Pooled funds, such as ECW and GPE, play a central role in supporting EiEPC. However, their disbursements are not systematically visible in global aid databases. In the CRS, GPE has been assigned donor and channel codes but does not submit data directly. ECW has not yet been assigned donor or channel codes. Absence of direct reporting does not mean these flows are missing. Bilateral donors report their contributions to these two funds. Tracing these flows requires keyword searches in the CRS, which can be partially verified using IATI data.

For example, ECW has consistently published data to IATI. Reported disbursements, expressed in 2022 constant USD, increased from USD 57 million in 2017 to USD 167 million in 2020 and USD 190 million in 2024. Donor-reported contributions in the CRS follow a broadly similar trend, though not identical (**Figure 2**). The divergence is due to the limitations of keyword-based searches as well as to differences in reporting practices.

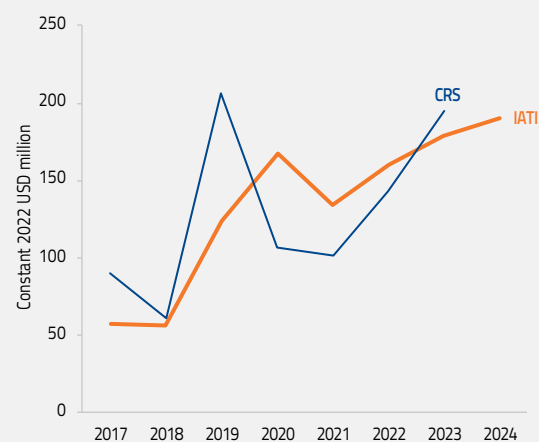
In 2022 and 2023, over 70% of the reported bilateral donor disbursements to ECW was coded as development aid in the CRS, but in 2020 and 2021 over 70% had been coded as humanitarian aid. This variation reflects inconsistencies in reporting standards and differing views on whether the work of ECW has a development or humanitarian focus. In contrast, ECW tags its disbursements to IATI consistently under education in emergencies.

A further limitation of the CRS is the lack of information on recipients. More than 80% of reported disbursements to ECW is listed as going to 'Developing countries, unspecified', which limits transparency. IATI, by contrast, provides more detailed recipient data. In 2024, for example, nearly half of ECW's disbursements were allocated to six countries: Bangladesh, Chad, Ethiopia, the State of Palestine, South Sudan and Ukraine. ECW's IATI reporting helps improve the transparency of information on its disbursements.

FIGURE 2.

ECW data reported to the CRS and IATI are broadly consistent

ECW disbursements reported to the CRS and IATI, constant 2022 USD million, 2017–24



Notes: Data were converted from current to constant 2022 USD values using GDP deflators (2019–23) and GDP current and constant prices (2024) from the IMF World Economic Outlook (April 2025) and World Development Indicators (2025).

Source: Authors' calculations based on the OECD CRS and IATI databases.

Data on UN agencies are also difficult to use. In the CRS, bilateral donors report their contributions to UN agencies, which typically represent core funding. In turn, UN agencies report to the CRS, particularly on the use of non-core or thematic funds, which are earmarked for specific purposes (OECD, 2024a; OECD, 2024b). For instance, UNICEF reported receiving USD 352 million in thematic contributions in 2023, accounting for 74% of its total thematic funding (UNICEF, 2024). The CRS estimated UNICEF's aid to education at USD 366 million in 2023 at constant prices. UNHCR also reports on its spending, but it appears as part of humanitarian aid, without sector-level detail.

In the IATI database, UN agencies tend to report their own disbursements. However, these records were excluded from this analysis to avoid double counting, as bilateral donors also report their contributions, for instance to the Central Emergency Response Fund managed by OCHA. Unlike the CRS, IATI does not have a mechanism for identifying and preventing duplicate records between reporting entities, which limits the comparability and aggregation of agency-reported data. Note also that data from the United Nations Relief and Works Agency for Palestine Refugees in the Near East are missing.

CRS, FTS AND IATI DATA AGREE ON THE DIRECTION OF AID TRENDS

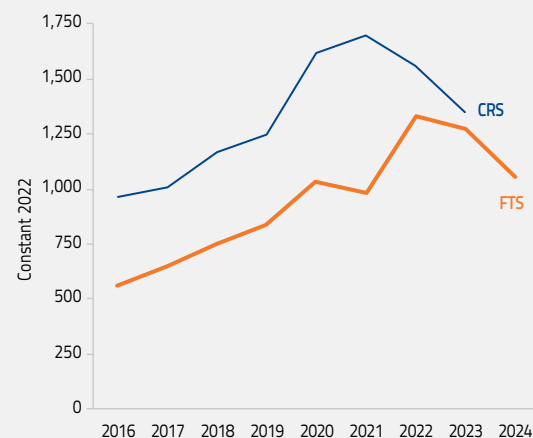
CRS and FTS data suggest that EiEPC financing increased rapidly by some USD 700 million in five years: in the case of the CRS, from USD 967 million in 2016 to USD 1.7 billion in 2021; and in the case of the FTS, from USD 564 million in 2016 to almost USD 1.33 billion in 2022. In both cases, it fell by about 20% in the following two years. At the same time, the CRS and the FTS differ considerably in the data they report. CRS aid volumes are one third higher than FTS aid volumes on average (Figure 3). The difference in volume reflects their distinct scopes and methodologies. The CRS includes both development and humanitarian aid reported by donors, whereas the FTS records humanitarian aid aligned with UN-coordinated appeals as well as outside such appeals, typically at the point of the initial commitment or when the contributions are paid to implementing agencies.

The share of EiEPC financed through humanitarian channels has declined steadily in the CRS database from 30% financing in 2017 to just 8% in 2023, the remainder coming from development aid channels (Figure 4). The humanitarian component has in fact shrunk in absolute terms since 2021.

FIGURE 3.

Data reported by the CRS and FTS differ in levels but the trends are broadly the same

EiEPC financing in the CRS database and EiE financing in the FTS database, in constant 2022 USD million, 2016–24



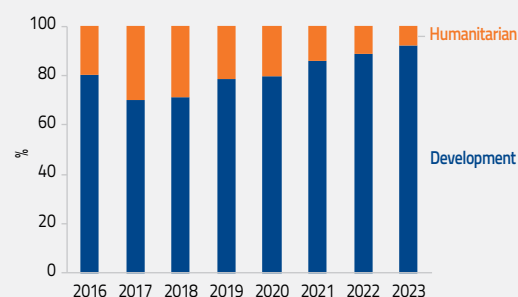
Notes: FTS data were downloaded in May 2025. Current values are converted to 2022 constant prices using GDP deflator (2019–23) and GDP current and constant prices (2024) from the IMF World Economic Outlook (April 2025) and World Development Indicators (2025).

Source: Authors' calculations based on the OECD CRS and OCHA FTS databases.

FIGURE 4.

EiEPC financing is increasingly dominated by development aid

Distribution of EiEPC financing in the CRS database, by type of aid, 2016–23



Source: Authors' calculations based on the OECD CRS database.

In terms of total aid to education, the share of EiEPC has increased from 9% in 2016 to 12% in 2023. When focusing only on countries with humanitarian response plans in place for more than three years (29 in 2023), the share rose from 21% to 24%.

The IATI database provides an additional perspective on EiEPC financing. According to the most recent data downloaded in May 2025, while EiEPC financing decreased by 20% in 2023, matching the CRS and FTS trends, it increased sharply from USD 952 million to USD 1,327 million in 2024, an increase driven primarily by development-related education aid

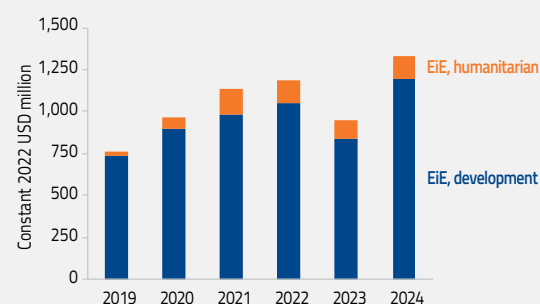


(Figure 5). At the same time, it should be noted that the increase in aid for EiEPC settings in 2024 goes against the clear signs of contraction in development aid to education by 12%, according to the IATI database (UNESCO, 2025c).

Comparing disbursement data for EiEPC settings in the CRS and IATI databases shows broadly similar patterns. However, notable differences in reported volumes remain in many cases, which limits the comparability of CRS and IATI aggregate data. There are structural differences between the two databases as well as variations in how donors apply reporting standards. Reporting to the CRS is highly institutionalized, with detailed guidance and validation processes. In contrast, IATI is a more recent and voluntary initiative. Some entities report income and others report disbursements. There is a risk of double-counting disbursements by some agencies. Not all implementing agencies of a bilateral donor report to IATI. A few donors, such as the European Union, the World Bank and, to some extent, the United States, report consistently to both the CRS and IATI, with similar trajectories and reported volumes. In contrast, data for Germany show the same trends but not the same levels, suggesting differences in reporting completeness (Figure 6). IATI reporting practices need to improve to ensure it can fully serve as a timelier complement to the CRS.

FIGURE 5.
IATI data suggest that EiEPC financing bounced back in 2024

EiEPC financing in the IATI database, by type of aid, 2019–24

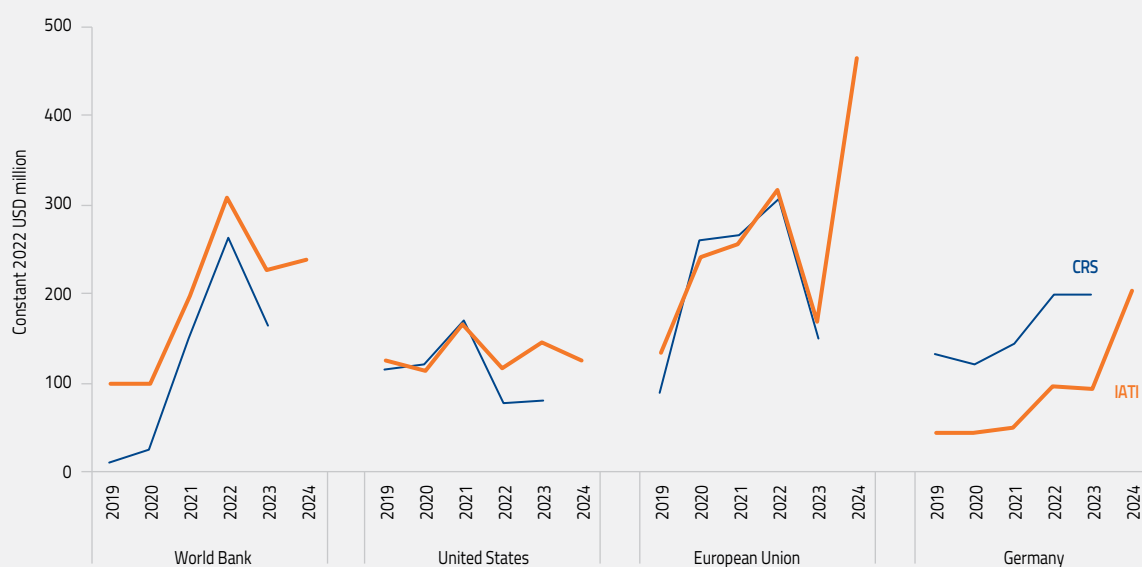


Notes: Current values are converted to 2022 constant prices using GDP deflator (2019–23) and GDP current and constant prices (2024) from the IMF World Economic Outlook (April 2025) and World Development Indicators (2025).

Source: Authors' calculations based on the IATI database.

FIGURE 6.
Several donors report consistently to the OECD CRS and IATI databases

EiEPC financing in the CRS and IATI databases, selected donors, 2019–24



Notes: Current values are converted to 2022 constant prices using GDP deflator (2019–23) and GDP current and constant prices (2024) from the IMF World Economic Outlook (April 2025) and World Development Indicators (2025).

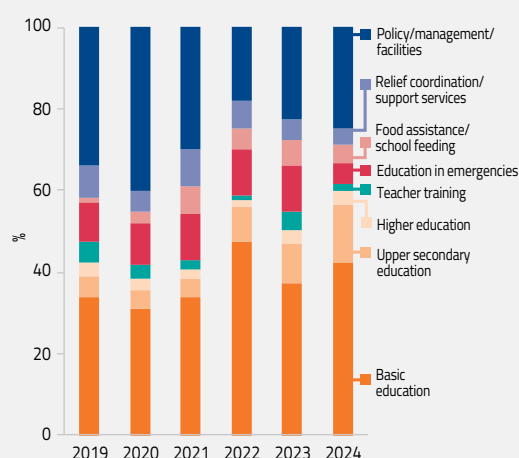
Source: Authors' calculations based on the OECD CRS and IATI databases.

One of the advantages of analysing the IATI database is the flexibility in disaggregation by subsector. Between 2019 and 2024, aid for EiEPC settings remained largely focused on basic education and sector-wide policy and management. On average, the share of basic education was almost 40%, while general support to policy, management and facilities was almost 30%. In contrast, the share of education in emergencies was about 10%, while the share of upper secondary education almost tripled from 5% in 2019 to 14% in 2024 (**Figure 7**).

FIGURE 7.

Two thirds of EiEPC financing goes to basic education and to education policy and management

EiEPC financing in the IATI database, by subsector, 2019–24



Source: Authors' calculations based on the IATI database.

INSIGHTS FROM A SIX-COUNTRY ANALYSIS OF EiEPC FINANCING DATA SOURCES

Estimates generated through harmonized filtering of the CRS, FTS and IATI databases offer a global overview of aid in EiEPC settings. These data help illuminate overall trends and volumes. To complement this analysis, data for six countries affected by conflict, displacement or fragility – Chad, the Democratic Republic of the Congo, Ethiopia, Haiti, Nigeria and South Sudan – were analysed in more depth to examine how humanitarian and development aid streams are captured and to what extent they align with each other.

Disbursement data between 2021 and 2024 were extracted from the FTS (transactions with 'education' and 'multi-sector with education' tags) and the IATI databases (transactions with education-related CRS sector codes: primary, secondary, post-secondary, vocational, education in emergencies and multisector training). The aim was to capture all labelled education transactions, whether humanitarian or development. They did not need to be explicitly labelled as related to crises, as the six countries are known to be

crisis-affected and are all among the 17 countries with a 'very high' score in the INFORM Risk Index.

This approach differs from the global analysis in two ways. First, the global analysis applied keyword filters to identify aid related to crises in all countries, many of which are not crisis-affected. Second, disbursements by UN agencies, such as UNICEF and UNHCR, were included in the six-country analysis, as these are likely to reflect direct programming. Some IATI records could not be verified due to incomplete reporting, but these accounted for just 4% of the total and were retained with caution.

In a second step, thematic filters were applied to identify support aligned with EiEPC priorities, such as inclusion, displacement and risk mitigation, even when not tagged as 'humanitarian' or 'education in emergencies'. Rather than a financial update, the analysis aims to identify gaps in how aid to education is tracked and interpreted across humanitarian and development streams, with the goal of informing future efforts to strengthen data for planning and coordination.

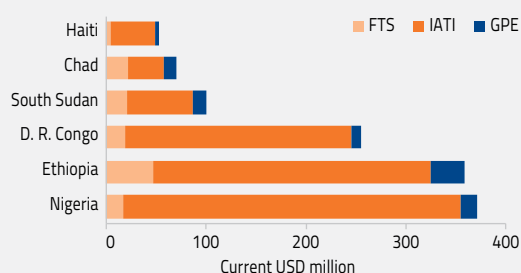
COMBINING FTS AND IATI DATA ADDS IMPORTANT INFORMATION

The data consolidation exercise showed that total aid to education disbursed in the six countries averaged approximately USD 1.1 billion per year. GPE disbursements, which are not reported through the FTS or IATI, were added separately based on publicly available data and amounted to some USD 90 million per year. Nigeria and Ethiopia received the highest volumes of financing at over USD 300 million (**Figure 8**). An analysis of transactions in the FTS and IATI databases showed that only 2% of cumulative education disbursements from 2021 to 2024 was in both data sets. This minimal overlap underscores the importance of not relying on a single source.

FIGURE 8.

FTS and IATI jointly provide a more complete picture, but key gaps remain

Annual average disbursements reported in FTS and IATI databases and estimated GPE disbursements, selected crisis-affected countries, 2021–24



Source: Authors' estimates based on the OCHA FTS and IATI databases, and the GPE website on active grants.



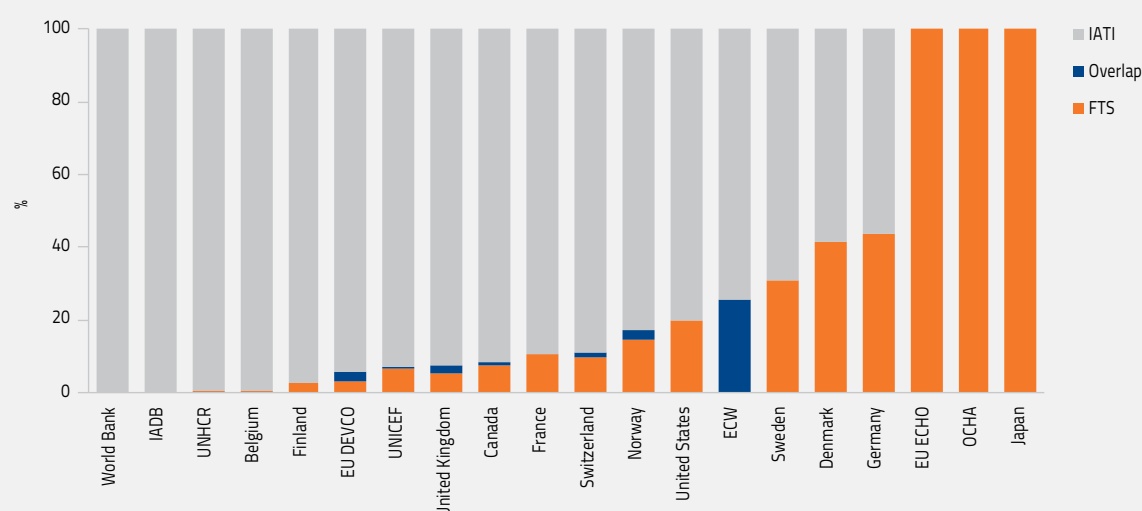
Donor reporting patterns further illustrate significant differences. Of the 20 top donors in the 6 countries, 3 reported solely to the FTS (ECHO, Japan and OCHA) and 4 (Belgium, Inter-American Development Bank, UNHCR and World Bank) reported exclusively through IATI. The three largest funders after the World Bank reported a variable share of their disbursements to the FTS: Germany (44%), the United States (20%) and the United Kingdom (5%), with limited or no duplication across data sets. This analysis highlights the added value of consolidating the two data sources in terms of improving transparency, accuracy and accountability in EIEPC financing (Figure 9).

Despite the severity of the crises and the substantial humanitarian education needs across all six countries, only 12% of reported funding appears in the FTS database after removing duplicate transactions. When the definition of 'humanitarian' funding is expanded to also include transactions marked as 'humanitarian' in the IATI database, the share of 'humanitarian' increases to 15%, ranging from lows of 6% in Nigeria and 9% in the Democratic Republic of the Congo to highs of 28% in South Sudan and 52% in Chad (Figure 10).

FIGURE 9.

One third of the top donors report to only one platform

Distribution of annual average disbursements on education, top 20 donors, by data source, selected crisis-affected countries, 2021–24



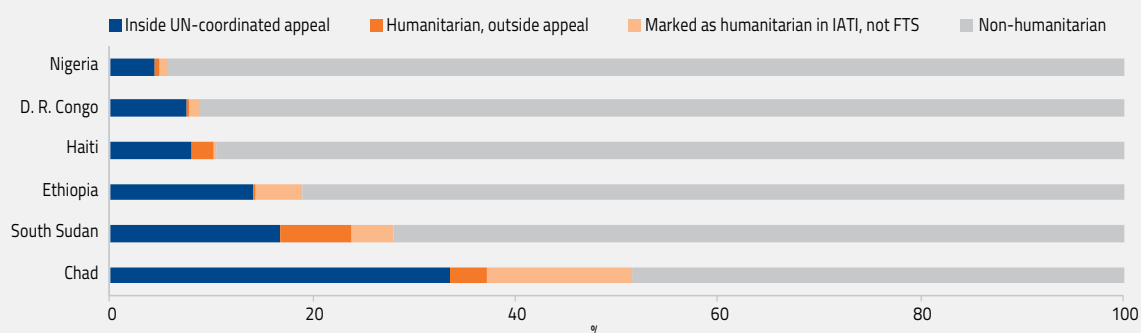
Notes: EU DEVCO = EU Directorate-General for International Cooperation and Development; EU ECHO = EU European Civil Protection and Humanitarian Aid Operations; IADB = Inter-American Development Bank. The countries analysed are Chad, the Democratic Republic of the Congo, Ethiopia, Haiti, Nigeria and South Sudan.

Source: Authors' estimates based on the OCHA FTS and IATI databases.

FIGURE 10.

Humanitarian aid to education represents a small proportion of funding even in crisis-affected countries

Share of humanitarian financing in total aid to education, six crisis-affected countries, 2021–24



Source: Authors' estimates based on the OCHA FTS and IATI databases.

These findings are not consistent with estimates of people in need of education assistance published by the Global Education Cluster, where Ethiopia had the highest number, followed by South Sudan, Nigeria and the Democratic Republic of the Congo (Global Education Cluster, 2024). The 2025 ECW estimates also identify Ethiopia, Nigeria and the Democratic Republic of the Congo as hosting the largest populations of crisis-affected school-age children. These findings show that there are major discrepancies between humanitarian needs and reported funding dedicated to address them.

However, these findings may also highlight inconsistencies in definitions and underreporting. The IATI humanitarian tag is neither mandatory nor consistently applied. A significant share of humanitarian funding may fall outside the scope of OCHA-coordinated appeals and some donors may choose not to report to the FTS at all. Another example of undercounting is that an estimated 49% of GPE funds were emergency (and COVID-19) response grants but were not included in the extracted IATI or FTS data. The narrowing scope of humanitarian appeals and the shifting of donor priorities, as funding gets tighter, further complicates the answer to what qualifies as 'humanitarian' funding.

THE IATI DATABASE ADDS INFORMATION ON DONOR PRIORITIES

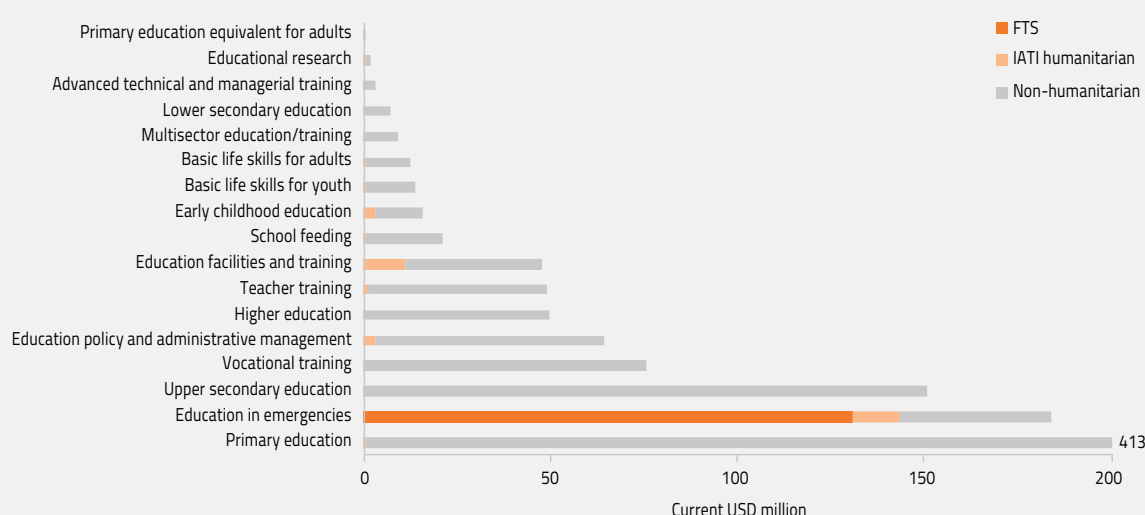
The FTS database lacks granular information on the type of education interventions funded; all funding is categorized as 'education in emergencies'. The IATI database can partially address this gap, as it includes standardized CRS codes for each reported transaction and richer activity descriptions. These provide insights into donor priorities, although it is important to note that some codes, such as education in emergencies and school feeding, are thematic rather than structural and do not specify which education levels are supported.

In the six countries reviewed, funding is concentrated in a few key areas. Between 2021 and 2024, primary education received the largest share (37%, an average of USD 413 million per year), followed by education in emergencies (16%) and upper secondary education (13%). Of the education in emergencies funding, 71% was derived from the FTS, while the remaining 29% was recorded in IATI, nearly a quarter of which was tagged as humanitarian (Figure 11). This suggests that relying on the FTS alone leads to systematic undercounting of education in emergency investments. IATI funding tagged as humanitarian extended beyond the education in emergencies subsector, appearing in areas such as early childhood education and education policy, which was primarily reported by UNICEF.

FIGURE 11.

Almost 40% of education financing in six crisis-affected countries goes to primary education

Annual average disbursements, by subsector, selected crisis-affected countries, 2021–24



Source: Authors' estimates based on the OCHA FTS and IATI databases.



From 2021 to 2024, among the top five donors in the six analysed countries, the United States (75%) and the World Bank (59%) prioritized primary education in their portfolios. Together, they accounted for 83% of the funding that went to primary education in these six countries. Germany prioritized education in emergencies (46%) and vocational training (41%), while the United Kingdom prioritized education policy (41%) and primary education (34%). The entire ECW portfolio is allocated to education in emergencies.

KEYWORD SEARCHES IN PROJECT DESCRIPTIONS INDICATE DONOR EIEPC PRIORITIES

Two more analyses of the data were carried out.

The **first** analysis was a review of titles and descriptions of education-related transactions in the FTS and IATI databases, using a structured keyword approach along four thematic dimensions: (i) emergency response and risk mitigation (e.g. humanitarian response, displacement, risk reduction and emergency-affected geographic areas); (ii) provision of safe and continuous education (e.g. protection, mental health and psychosocial support, water, sanitation and hygiene, school feeding, and education facilities); (iii) inclusive and gender-transformative education (e.g. gender, disability and inclusion); and (iv) quality of learning (e.g. learning, teachers and education continuity).

In total, 56% of the transactions were matched to at least one keyword; the rest was not matched, often due to limited or generic project descriptions. While this was not a detailed review of transaction content, it helped highlight that education investments frequently prioritized areas such as gender (35%), humanitarian crises (22%) and quality of learning (22%), whether as stand-alone or integrated components.

Keyword themes were correlated with each other. For example, 41% of gender-tagged transactions also included humanitarian response keywords and 48% included quality of learning keywords, suggesting an integrated approach to equity in crisis contexts. Many water and sanitation-tagged transactions also included protection, humanitarian crisis and displacement keywords, suggesting the central role of water and sanitation in safe, inclusive learning environments. References to protection also commonly intersected with displacement, inclusion and risk reduction, suggesting that safety-focused

interventions often span multiple thematic priorities. By contrast, transactions with a quality of learning tag did not overlap with other categories, suggesting less integration into broader EIEPC responses. No transactions were tagged under out-of-school children or mental health and psychosocial support.

The **second** analysis compared thematic tags with education subsector categories to gain insights into how crisis-related priorities are being operationalized. For example, the education in emergencies subsector is the principal delivery channel for crisis-responsive funding, capturing most investments tagged for displacement (84%), water and sanitation (73%), protection (65%) and risk reduction (41%). Primary education also captured large shares of funding tagged with gender (55%), humanitarian crises (69%) and inclusion (69%). Themes such as inclusion, learning, risk reduction and teacher support are distributed across a broader set of subsectors. However, this breadth is not matched by scale.

Some crisis-related priority themes, such as displacement, water and sanitation, protection and geographic targeting, remain highly concentrated in education in emergencies and in primary education. Conversely, several subsectors, such as early childhood education, secondary education, basic life skills for youth and adults, and higher education, are disconnected from investments with a crisis tag, despite their relevance to long-term recovery and continuity. Overall, while some subsectors can be effective channels for delivering interventions related to crises, others, notably post-primary education and governance, are not utilized.

Keyword tagging has significant limitations, however. The approach relies on the accuracy and specificity of transaction descriptions, and automated tagging can misclassify records. For instance, the World Bank's large-scale systems reform programme in the Democratic Republic of the Congo was flagged as a 'humanitarian response' based solely on its title, even though it was primarily a development operation. In contrast, ECW's crisis-focused funding was often missed due to vague descriptions. Still, keyword tagging helped to make some interventions visible, including protection programmes funded by Norway and contributions from the United States that were aligned with EIEPC goals but not were not explicitly labelled as education in emergencies.

CONCLUSION

The global and six-country analysis of the CRS, FTS and IATI databases can be summarized in key findings which lead, in turn, to a set of recommendations.

KEY FINDINGS

Four key findings emerge from the use of multiple sources on aid in EiEPC settings at the global and country level.

The division in reporting between humanitarian and development financing undermines coherent tracking of education support in crises

In crisis contexts, education interventions pursue both humanitarian and development goals. While system strengthening is typically viewed as a development actor priority, humanitarian actors also build resilience to reduce the need for repeated emergency responses, often through similar strategies. Development agencies and governments are also increasingly encouraged to integrate education in emergencies into broader education sector planning.

Despite this convergence, reporting systems continue to categorize interventions as either humanitarian or development, based on definitions that are not universally agreed upon. What qualifies as humanitarian aid is shaped not only by technical, but also by political and institutional factors. Classifications vary depending on whether there is an appeal, the type of crisis, the scope of the intervention, or the agency reporting the funding. Recent efforts of 'humanitarian boundary setting' to narrow the scope of humanitarian aid have added to this complexity. Reporting systems also differ in how they capture and code such information. These inconsistencies across donors, partners and databases fragment the overall picture of education financing in crisis settings and limit the ability to track trends or compare data across countries.

A growing share of education support in crisis contexts is channelled through development assistance

The global analysis in this paper found that the development share of EiEPC funding in the CRS database rose from 70% in 2017 to 92% in 2023. Conversely, in six crisis-affected countries also analysed in this paper, only 12% of aid to education appeared in the FTS database, while just 3% of transactions were explicitly marked as 'humanitarian' and 5% as 'education in emergencies' in the IATI database. These findings call for a broader approach to tracking EiEPC funding that integrates the three databases. Using this expanded lens enables over-time and cross-country comparative analysis of EiEPC funding. Two key findings were that, while the proportion of humanitarian funding within EiEPC declined, the overall share of aid to education with EiEPC objectives increased

from 9% in 2016 to 12% in 2023 – and from 21% to 24% in countries with humanitarian response plans in place for more than three years.

Combining multiple databases improves the transparency of aid to education flows

No single data system captures the full picture of education financing in crisis contexts. The CRS, FTS and IATI offer distinct but partial perspectives. The CRS provides the most structured and validated information, with standardized coding that allows trend analysis, but its data are delayed and often lack crisis-specific tags. The FTS focuses on humanitarian contributions but lacks detail at the subsector level and only captures first-level transfers rather than their ultimate use. IATI offers flexible tagging and more real-time data across humanitarian and development streams, but is used inconsistently.

However, when used together, the data sets provide a more complete view of who is funding what, where and with what priorities. As argued above, this approach, using multiple sources, made it possible to identify transactions aligned with EiEPC goals that would not have been visible through humanitarian reporting alone. The combined approach also enabled a clearer picture of the total funding volume. In the CRS, global funding for education in emergencies rose from USD 967 billion in 2016 to USD 1.7 billion in 2021 and to USD 1.35 billion in 2023. IATI, while less comprehensive in its donor coverage, shows an increase for 2024. Still, the complementarity of these tools is undermined by inconsistent tagging, irregular data uploads, lack of donor coverage and fragmented standards across platforms. Without harmonized reporting, the full potential of these databases will remain untapped.

Tagging methods can inform future funding priorities

Thematic tagging was applied across the CRS, FTS and IATI to assess whether and to what extent aid to education is aligned with crisis-related priorities. While the accuracy of results depends on the quality of reporting, the analysis helped identify the areas of concentration and thematic gaps in funding. Globally, EiEPC-related disbursements were primarily allocated to primary education and policy support. In the six countries, thematic filters identified 56% of total disbursements as relevant to crisis response, although only 18% were formally coded under the education in emergencies subsector, pointing to inconsistencies between the programme focus and sector classification.

Further analysis showed uneven alignment across themes and subsectors. Some themes, such as inclusion and displacement, appeared across a wide range of interventions, suggesting integrated programming. Others remained limited to specific areas. No transactions were tagged under out-of-school children or mental health



and psychosocial support, raising questions about either reporting practices or prioritization. Subsectors such as early childhood education, lower secondary education, basic life skills and higher education showed limited alignment with crisis-related themes, despite their relevance to recovery and continuity. While constrained by reporting quality, the exercise demonstrates the potential of thematic tagging to improve transparency, identify overlooked areas, and support more coherent and needs-based education responses in crisis contexts.

RECOMMENDATIONS

This paper highlights a range of problems in how EiEPC financing is tracked and understood. It shows that while substantial funding support is reaching learners, much of it is not clearly visible in global databases due to inconsistent reporting, fragmented classifications and the underuse of existing tools. A more coordinated approach across humanitarian and development systems is needed to ensure that education funding is transparent so that it can be targeted and aligned with needs.

Align data systems to reflect the full scope of crisis-related education funding

Humanitarian and development financing are combined in practice, especially in protracted crises. Yet global reporting platforms do not reflect this. To support more accurate tracking, donors and reporting entities should adopt a common approach to identifying EiEPC-related funding across all aid modalities. This includes consistently applying relevant sector codes and markers and recognizing the role of development programming in crisis response.

Improve reporting standards and classification practices in the CRS, FTS and IATI

The underreporting of EiEPC-related funding is linked not only to data gaps but also to how information is classified. Donors and UN agencies should strengthen internal reporting procedures to ensure key fields, such as provider, recipient and purpose codes, are properly filled in. Database managers should enforce the use of existing tags (e.g. the humanitarian flag in IATI) and promote clearer guidance on when and how to apply them. Greater consistency will improve both the quality and comparability of data across systems.

Enhance collaboration among data platforms and reporting agencies

No single data set can provide a complete picture of education aid in crisis settings. As demonstrated in this exercise, the combined use of the CRS, FTS and IATI yields richer insights. To make this approach sustainable, stronger collaboration is needed across platforms and among key reporting agencies. This includes technical coordination

to harmonize taxonomies, develop cross-referencing mechanisms, and reduce duplication in reporting. Shared efforts can support more integrated, reliable tracking of EiEPC financing.

Make comparable education funding data accessible and actionable

Consolidating education financing data from the CRS, FTS and IATI is essential to improve the availability, accessibility and usability of information for decision makers at all levels. From global policy actors to national planners and local implementers, stakeholders need a clearer picture of past disbursements, persistent funding gaps and priority needs. Integrated data will enable evidence-based planning, coordination and advocacy; help leverage existing resources more strategically; and direct decision makers to the most pressing and context-specific educational needs. Joint efforts should focus on building a shared, transparent and timely evidence base that can inform decisions across the humanitarian–development continuum.

This paper is a collaboration between the *Global Education Monitoring Report* and Education Cannot Wait. The research was led by Yuki Murakami (GEM Report) and Francesca Pinna (ECW), under the guidance of Manos Antoninis (GEM Report) and Christian Stoff (ECW). Baptiste Gorteau (GEM Report) and Claudia Manili (ECW) supported data extraction and analysis. Andy Quan edited, Aurélia Mazoyer designed and Madeleine Barry produced the paper, while Kate Redman led on communications (GEM Report).

Global Education Monitoring Report

UNESCO

7, place de Fontenoy

75352 Paris 07 SP, France

Email: gemreport@unesco.org

Tel: +33 (1) 45 68 10 36

www.unesco.org/gem-report/en**Education Cannot Wait**

ECW Headquarters 633 3rd Ave.,

23rd floor New York,

NY 10017, USA

Email: info@un-ecw.org<https://www.educationcannotwait.org/>

Developed by an independent team and published by UNESCO, the Global Education Monitoring Report is an authoritative reference that aims to inform, influence and sustain genuine commitment towards the global education targets in the Sustainable Development Goals (SDGs) framework.

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